Weeks 7–8: Group Activity Worksheet

Design Forensics — Technique, Software and the Assignment 1 Report

Tutorial Objective: Continue your Weeks 3–4 system chart. Choose **one** target design, work out the **techniques** and **software** most likely used to make it, rebuild its production workflow, and complete everything as your **Assignment 1** report.

Assessment: Individual Assignment 1 — *Analyse an Existing Design System* (30%) · PDF via Blackboard · **Submission in Week 9**

Two-Week Plan

Week	Activity
7	Briefing: design forensics and the Assignment 1 brief
	Part A – Select the target and collect more evidence
	Part B – Technique and software investigation
	Part C – Rebuild the production workflow (draft)
8	**Part D** – Verification test (recreate one fragment)
	Part E – Assemble the Assignment 1 report
	Part F – Peer review of the draft
	Action plan for final submission

Materials and Software

☐ Your Weeks 3–4 system chart (PDF + editable files)
☐ Laptop with internet and a modern browser (Chrome / Edge / Firefox)
☐ Figma / Illustrator / Photoshop / Photopea for the verification test
☐ Font identification: WhatTheFont, WhatFontIs, Adobe Fonts visual search
☐ Colour tools: Adobe Color (extract theme), Coolors, browser eyedropper
☐ Browser tools (for websites / web apps): DevTools (F12), WhatFont extension, Wappalyzer
☐ An online EXIF / metadata viewer (for downloaded image files)

Student Information

Field	Details
English Full Name	
Student ID	
Tutorial Class	
Peer Review Partner	

Part A: Select Your Target Design (Week 7)

A.1 Choose from Your Five Items

Item # (from W3–4)	Brand / Title	Enough material to analyse?	Interesting techniques?	Score *(1–5)*
1		☐	☐	
2		☐	☐	
3		☐	☐	
4		☐	☐	
5		☐	☐	

My target design: _____ Teacher approval (initials): _____

Why this design? (3–4 sentences)

A.2 Collect More Evidence from the Same System

A single image is not enough to prove a system. Collect **at least 5 more assets** from the same brand / product (other posters, pages, screens, packaging, social posts, ads, the logo, any brand guidelines).

#	Asset	Where Found (URL / place)	Date	What It Adds to My Analysis
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Designer / agency / studio credit (if found): _____

Search: "[brand] + case study", "[brand] + Behance", "[brand] + brand guidelines", "[brand] + redesign", agency websites, design award sites.

Part B: Technique and Software Investigation (Week 7)

B.1 Clue Guide — Reading the Evidence

What You See	Likely Technique	Likely Software
Perfectly sharp edges, flat colour, scales without blur	Vector illustration	Illustrator, Figma, Affinity Designer
Photo with objects merged, cut-outs, soft shadows	Photo compositing / retouching	Photoshop, Photopea, Affinity Photo
Brush strokes, paper grain, uneven line	Hand-drawn or digital painting	Procreate, Fresco, Photoshop; scanned artwork
Realistic lighting on objects that don't exist	3D modelling and rendering	Blender, Cinema 4D, KeyShot
Consistent UI components, auto spacing, icons in a set	UI design system	Figma, Sketch, Adobe XD
Long text layouts, columns, consistent paragraph styles	Desktop publishing	InDesign, Affinity Publisher
Animated transitions, kinetic type	Motion design	After Effects, Lottie, Rive, CSS animation
Uncanny details, inconsistent hands / text, "too perfect" textures	Generative AI imagery	Midjourney, Firefly, DALL·E, Stable Diffusion

B.2 Investigation Methods — Tick What You Tried

Method	How	☐	Finding
Zoom test	Zoom to 400%+: pixels = raster, crisp = vector	☐	
Font ID	Upload a crop of the text to a font identifier	☐	
Colour extraction	Eyedropper → HEX values; Adobe Color "Extract theme"	☐	
Metadata	Check the image file in an EXIF viewer (look for a "Software" field)	☐	
Browser inspect *(web/app)*	DevTools → Elements / Computed → fonts, colours, spacing, CSS grid	☐	
Tech stack *(web)*	Wappalyzer → frameworks / CMS	☐	
Credits & case study	Agency site, Behance, interviews	☐	
Comparison	Compare with known work made in a specific tool	☐	

B.3 Component-by-Component Analysis

Break the target design into components and investigate each one.

Component	Observed Evidence	Technique Guess	Software Guess	Confidence *(H/M/L)*	Method Used to Check
Main image / illustration					
Logo / brand mark					
Headline typography					
Body typography					
Background / texture					

B.3 Component-by-Component Analysis *(continued)*

Component	Observed Evidence	Technique Guess	Software Guess	Confidence *(H/M/L)*	Method Used to Check
Colour treatment *(gradient, duotone, grading)*					
Effects *(shadow, blur, grain, mask)*					
Layout / grid *(from W3–4)*					
Icons / UI elements					
Motion / interaction *(if any)*					

B.4 Typography and Colour Specification

Typography

Role	Typeface (identified)	Classification *(serif / sans / display / script)*	Weight	Approx. Size	Alternative if Not Exact
Headline					
Subhead					
Body					

Colour Palette

Role	HEX	RGB	Where It Is Used	Proportion *(approx. %)*
Primary				
Secondary				
Accent				
Neutral / background				

Part C: Rebuild the Production Workflow (Week 7)

Based on your evidence, write the most likely step-by-step process the design team followed, from brief to final output.

Stage	What the Designer Did	Software / Tool	Output of This Stage	Evidence for This Guess
1. Brief & research				
2. Concept & sketching				
3. Grid & layout set-up				
4. Asset creation *(photo / illustration / 3D)*				
5. Typography & copy				
6. Colour & finishing				
7. Export & delivery *(print / web / app formats)*				

C.1 Workflow Diagram

Draw your reconstructed workflow as a **flowchart**: boxes for stages, arrows for flow, icons or labels for software, and loops where you think the team revised and iterated.

End of Week 7 progress check (teacher's initials): _____

Part D: Verification Test (Week 8)

*Test one hypothesis by recreating a **small fragment** of the target design (e.g. the headline lock-up, one icon, a texture or one section of the layout) with the software you guessed.*

Item	Details
Fragment chosen	
Hypothesis tested *(e.g. "The grain is a noise layer in Photoshop set to Overlay")*	
Software used	
Steps taken	
Time taken	
Result	☐ Confirmed ☐ Partly confirmed ☐ Not confirmed

What does this result tell you? Do you need to change your guess in Part B?

Put a side-by-side image (original vs. your recreation) in the report.

Part E: Assemble the Assignment 1 Report (Week 8)

E.1 Required Report Structure (6–10 pages)

Section	Content	Source in This Course	☐
Cover	Title, target design, name, student ID, class	—	☐
1. Introduction	Target design, brand context, audience, why chosen	A.1, A.2	☐
2. Visual Elements	Dot, line, shape, space, colour, texture, with annotated images	W2, W3–4, B.4	☐
3. Design Principles	Movement, balance, emphasis, unity, with annotations	W3–4 Part C	☐
4. Grid, Hierarchy & Layout	Line drawings, grid specs, reading order, system rules	W3–4 Parts B–D	☐
5. Technique & Software	Component analysis, typography, colour, evidence	B.3, B.4	☐
6. Reconstructed Workflow	Step table + flowchart + verification test	Part C, Part D	☐
7. Conclusion	What makes this system work; key insights	—	☐
References	APA 7th, including image sources and AI tools used	—	☐

E.2 Report Writing Checklist

☐ Every claim is supported by an **annotated image** or evidence
☐ Annotations use arrows, colour codes and labels (not just plain screenshots)
☐ Technical terms are used correctly (margin, gutter, hierarchy, raster, vector…)
☐ Confidence levels are stated for technique and software guesses
☐ The layout of the report itself uses a **consistent grid** and type hierarchy
☐ Images are high resolution and properly cropped
☐ AI tools used (if any) are declared, with the prompts listed in the appendix
☐ Spelling and grammar checked

E.3 Page Plan

Sketch thumbnails of your report pages (8–12 small rectangles) showing where text and images go.

Part F: Peer Review of the Draft (Week 8)

Swap drafts with your partner. Review against the assessment focus and fill in the table **for them**.

Criterion	Rating *(1–5)*	Comment
Depth of visual element and principle analysis	/5	
Accuracy of grid, hierarchy and layout analysis	/5	
Strength of evidence for technique and software guesses	/5	
Clarity of the reconstructed workflow	/5	
Visual presentation and annotations	/5	

Reviewer name: _____

The one thing that would improve this report most:

Final Action Plan (before Week 9 submission)

#	Action Item	Based on (feedback / self-check)	Deadline	Done
1				☐
2				☐
3				☐
4				☐
5				☐

Reflection

What was the most surprising thing you discovered about how your target design was made?

Blackboard Submission

Weekly Progress Upload (end of Week 8)

Item	Requirement
Content	This completed worksheet (Parts A–F) + draft report
File Name	`W07-08_[EnglishFullName]_[StudentNumber].pdf`
Location	Blackboard → SSHD2382 → Weeks 7–8 → Progress

Assignment 1 Final Submission

Item	Requirement
Format	PDF, 6–10 pages, annotated images, diagrams and written explanation
File Name	`[EnglishFullName]_[StudentNumber].pdf`
Location	Blackboard → SSHD2382 → Assessments → Individual Assignment 1
Deadline	**Week 9** (see Blackboard for exact date and time)

Additional Notes

References & Resources

Record all sources (brand websites, case studies, font and colour tools, articles, AI tools and prompts) in APA 7th style: